

which when chosen, will take you through a page where you can set up your network and select a mirror (choose the one nearest to you for maximum speed).

Step 2: Set the clock. You can choose from a list of continents, then countries (and then cities if the selected country has more than one city listed). I chose Asia and then India. So Asia/Kolkata was the result. The installer will then ask you to set the date and time.

Step 3: Prepare the hard drive. This step enables you to prepare your hard drive. The installer detects your hard drive first. You can then either choose 'Auto-prepare', which will use your entire hard drive (and erase any partitions present previously) or you can choose 'Partition Hard Drive' which will take you to *cfdisk*. This is familiar territory for any intermediate Linux user. I was going to install only Arch on my laptop. But still, I wanted to be able to choose how much of my hard drive I was going to allocate to */*, swap and */home*. I have a 320 GB hard drive on my laptop. So I allocated 2GB for swap, 20 GB for */*, made the partition bootable and allocated the rest to */home* and wrote changes to my hard drive. The next step here was to set the filesystem mount points. This is where I was going to instruct the operating system about which partition to use for what, and this is where you can choose between ext2, ext3 and ext4, among other filesystems.

Step 4: Select packages. There are two options available here—base and base-devel. The former has everything you need for a basic system and 'base-devel' contains other packages that are optional and not as important as 'base'. This is pretty much like the first and second Debian CDs. The first one containing all the necessary packages and the second with all the packages that are next in line, in terms of importance. It is recommended that you choose all the packages in base. Choose packages in base-devel is up to you.

Step 5: Install packages. This step is mandatory and will install all the packages you chose in the previous step.

Step 6: Configure system. Once all the selected packages have been installed, the installer will present you with a list of configuration files starting from *rc.conf* (the system configuration file) where you can configure your hostname, network settings (if you have a DHCP server for your wired connection, change the line in the networking section starting with *eth0*, or the interface that is present, to *eth0="dhcp"*), the root password (Arch does not ask you to set up another user; you'll have to do it once the system is installed using the *useradd* command), among others. You can edit the configuration files using either Nano or Vim.

Step 7: Install the boot loader. While the previous versions of Arch had an option to install either GRUB or LILO, 2009.02 has the option to install GRUB or nothing at all (use this option if you already have another Linux OS in a separate partition, in which case, don't forget to add the Arch listing to the original GRUB *menu.lst* file).

You're done installing the base system. Reboot the system (and make sure you remove the CD from the optical drive to prevent the installer from starting again) and that's it.

The X factor

Before you install anything, make sure you create a new user with *useradd* and that your current system is up to date. A *pacman -S pacman* followed by a *pacman -Sy* and *pacman -Su* will update the system. Make sure you do this as the new user.

Use *pacman -S xorg* to install the X window system. Once installed, use *xorg -configure* or a *pacman -S hwd*, followed by a *hwd -xa* to configure X. In case you use a laptop and you find that your touchpad is not recognised, do a *pacman -S xf86-input-synaptics* to install the 'synaptics' driver (most laptops have a synaptic touchpad).

Now that X is in place, it's time to install a desktop environment—I'll set up GNOME here:

```
pacman -S gnome gnome-extra gnome-system-tools \
networkmanager network-manager-applet \
alsa-lib alsa-utils alsa-oss.
```

This will install GNOME, ALSA and NetworkManager. Once done, make sure you add *hal*, *network-manager*, *alsa* and *fam* daemons to the daemons section in */etc/rc.conf*. My daemons section looked like this.

```
DAEMONS=(syslog-ng network netfs crond gdm hal fam networkmanager
network-manager-applet alsa)
```

That is all you need. You now have a usable system. You can install The GIMP, OpenOffice.org, Python and the likes with just *pacman -S package_name*. Oh, and don't forget to do a 'system update' now and then. Happy Arching!



Ratings

Installer	4/5
Ease of use	3.5/5
Features	5/5
Stability	4.5/5
Community	5/5
Overall	4.5/5

References

- Arch home: www.archlinux.org
- Arch wiki: wiki.archlinux.org
- Forum: bbs.archlinux.org
- Arch User Repo link: aur.archlinux.org
- Screenshots taken from: ebalaskas.gr/ArchLinux. If you want screenshots of the entire installation process, this is where you'll find it.

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